

Task 1: Select and Prioritise Potential Members

Friends of Finance — Growth Squad Assessment

1. Objective

The objective of this exercise is to identify finance professionals who could be a good fit for Friends of Finance (FoF), understand what they could gain from the community, and assess what they could contribute to other members.

Friends of Finance is a professional community for finance and accounting professionals. Its focus is on sharing real work experiences, practical finance problems, useful tools and systems, career experiences, and peer-to-peer learning. The community is built around the idea of **“Real finance work. Shared openly.”**

For this exercise, I focused mainly on finance professionals based in India and used publicly available professional information. I did not contact any of the individuals.

2. Potential Members Identified

1. Dhiraj Kumar Vashista

Current role: Whole Time Director & Chief Financial Officer

Company: HGS (India) Limited

Location: India

Relevant public signal

Dhiraj Vashista has around 27 years of experience in accounts and finance. His background includes FP&A, governance, budgeting, supply-chain optimisation and finance transformation. He was also recognised among the 10 Best CFOs in India in 2026 and received a Best CFO recognition from BW CFO World in 2026.

Why Friends of Finance may be useful to him

His experience covers several areas that are directly relevant to the community. He could use FoF to exchange practical experiences with other finance leaders, especially around transformation, planning and improving finance operations.

What he could contribute

He could share practical experiences from finance leadership, FP&A, budgeting, governance and transformation. His senior-level perspective could also be useful to members who are moving towards finance leadership roles.

Most relevant Friends of Finance spaces

- Finance Workflows
- Ask Finance Peers
- Career & Compensation

Score

Area	Score
Community relevance	5/5
Potential contribution	5/5
Likely member value	5/5
Strength of evidence	5/5
Total	20/20

Sources: HGS official website; LinkedIn public profile/activity.

2. Harshit Vora

Current role: Chief Financial Officer

Company: John Deere Financial India Private Limited

Location: Pune, Maharashtra

Relevant public signal

Harshit Vora was appointed CFO of John Deere Financial India in March 2024. His public profile describes experience across finance, treasury and financial services, and he has recently shared professional thoughts around AI and the changing role of finance professionals.

Why Friends of Finance may be useful to him

His combination of finance leadership and treasury experience could make peer discussions around finance operations, technology and decision-making useful.

What he could contribute

He could contribute perspectives on treasury, financial services, risk management, finance leadership and the use of technology in finance.

Most relevant Friends of Finance spaces

- Finance Workflows
- Tools & Systems
- Ask Finance Peers

Score

Area	Score
Community relevance	5/5
Potential contribution	5/5
Likely member value	5/5
Strength of evidence	5/5

Area	Score
Total	20/20

Sources: John Deere official disclosures; public LinkedIn profile.

3. Sushanta Kumar Swain

Current role: Vice President — Finance

Company: Matrimony.com Limited

Location: Chennai, Tamil Nadu

Relevant public signal

Sushanta Kumar Swain has more than 30 years of finance experience and was recognised in the CFONext100 awards for expertise in tax management. More recently, he participated in the 45th India CFO Summit 2026 in Chennai and spoke about AI, data, digital innovation and the changing role of CFOs.

Why Friends of Finance may be useful to him

His long experience in finance and recent interest in AI and digital transformation make him a strong fit for a community where experienced professionals can share practical lessons with peers.

What he could contribute

He could contribute senior finance perspectives, tax experience and practical thoughts on using technology and data in finance.

Most relevant Friends of Finance spaces

- Finance Workflows
- Tools & Systems
- Ask Finance Peers

Score

Area	Score
Community relevance	5/5
Potential contribution	5/5
Likely member value	5/5
Strength of evidence	5/5
Total	20/20

Sources: Matrimony.com public announcement; public LinkedIn profile; CFO summit information.

4. Prantik Dam

Current role: Finance Director / Business Transformation Strategist

Company: The CFO Centre India

Location: Bengaluru, Karnataka

Relevant public signal

Prantik Dam's public profile describes him as a finance director and business transformation strategist with around 35 years of experience. His recent professional activity focuses on helping business leaders deal with complexity, compliance, transition and high-impact decisions.

Why Friends of Finance may be useful to him

The community's focus on real finance situations and peer learning matches his background in advising businesses through finance and transformation challenges.

What he could contribute

He could share lessons from long-term finance leadership, business transformation, decision-making and working with senior management.

Most relevant Friends of Finance spaces

- Finance Workflows
- Ask Finance Peers
- Career & Compensation

Score

Area	Score
Community relevance	5/5
Potential contribution	5/5
Likely member value	4/5
Strength of evidence	5/5
Total	19/20

Source: Public LinkedIn profile.

5. Kiran Deshmukh

Current role: Finance Leader

Company: Shapoorji Pallonji Finance Private Limited

Location: Mumbai, Maharashtra

Relevant public signal

Kiran Deshmukh's public profile describes him as a finance leader interested in transforming financial strategy into scalable business outcomes. His recent public activity also includes discussions around AI and machine learning in BFSI.

Why Friends of Finance may be useful to him

His combination of finance and technology interests fits well with the community's discussions around finance transformation and tools.

What he could contribute

He could contribute practical views on financial strategy, financial services and the application of AI and technology in finance.

Most relevant Friends of Finance spaces

- Tools & Systems
- Finance Workflows
- Ask Finance Peers

Score

Area	Score
Community relevance	4/5
Potential contribution	5/5
Likely member value	4/5
Strength of evidence	4/5
Total	17/20

Source: Public LinkedIn profile.

6. Tania Saha

Current role: Finance Manager / FP&A Professional

Company: Cisco

Location: Bengaluru, Karnataka

Relevant public signal

Tania Saha's public profile describes her as a Finance Manager and FP&A professional with an interest in digital transformation. Her public activity also includes engagement with finance hiring and career-related discussions.

Why Friends of Finance may be useful to her

FP&A professionals can benefit from peer discussions around forecasting, planning, business partnering and career development. These areas are closely connected to the practical focus of Friends of Finance.

What she could contribute

She could bring a more hands-on FP&A perspective, particularly around planning, finance transformation and career development.

Most relevant Friends of Finance spaces

- Finance Workflows
- Career & Compensation
- Ask Finance Peers

Score

Area	Score
Community relevance	5/5
Potential contribution	4/5
Likely member value	5/5
Strength of evidence	4/5
Total	18/20

Source: Public LinkedIn profile.

7. Akhil Malhotra

Current role: Finance Transformation Professional

Company: PwC

Location: Delhi, India

Relevant public signal

Akhil Malhotra's public profile describes more than 23 years of experience in finance transformation and shared services. His public activity includes discussions around FP&A careers, finance operations and improving efficiency in large-scale finance functions.

Why Friends of Finance may be useful to him

Finance transformation is one of the areas where peer learning can be particularly valuable because professionals often face similar process, technology and adoption challenges.

What he could contribute

He could share experience from large finance operations, transformation programmes, shared services and FP&A.

Most relevant Friends of Finance spaces

- Tools & Systems
- Finance Workflows
- Ask Finance Peers

Score

Area	Score
Community relevance	5/5
Potential contribution	5/5
Likely member value	5/5
Strength of evidence	5/5
Total	20/20

Source: Public LinkedIn profile.

8. Ritesh Kumar

Current role: CFO / Finance Leadership Professional

Company: Finance leadership background including Michelin

Location: India

Relevant public signal

His public professional profile highlights experience across CFO responsibilities, FP&A, financial transformation, M&A and treasury. His earlier role at Michelin involved leading finance during a business turnaround, including finance systems, policies and processes.

Why Friends of Finance may be useful to him

His experience covers both strategic finance and day-to-day finance transformation, which matches the practical nature of the community.

What he could contribute

He could contribute examples from finance transformation, treasury, FP&A, M&A and building finance processes during periods of change.

Most relevant Friends of Finance spaces

- Finance Workflows

- Tools & Systems
- Ask Finance Peers

Score

Area	Score
Community relevance	5/5
Potential contribution	5/5
Likely member value	5/5
Strength of evidence	4/5
Total	19/20

Source: Public professional profile.

3. Scoring Summary

Rank	Professional	Relevance	Contribution	Member Value	Evidence	Total
1	Dhiraj Kumar Vashista	5	5	5	5	20
2	Harshit Vora	5	5	5	5	20
3	Sushanta Kumar Swain	5	5	5	5	20
4	Akhil Malhotra	5	5	5	5	20
5	Prantik Dam	5	5	4	5	19
6	Ritesh Kumar	5	5	5	4	19
7	Tania Saha	5	4	5	4	18
8	Kiran Deshmukh	4	5	4	4	17

The scores are not intended to mean that one person is objectively better than another. They are an assessment of how well each person's publicly visible professional background matches the purpose of Friends of Finance.

4. Top Three Candidates

1. Dhiraj Kumar Vashista

Dhiraj stands out because of the combination of senior finance leadership, FP&A, governance, budgeting and transformation experience. His public profile also provides strong and recent evidence of active engagement in the finance leadership space.

His experience would fit naturally into **Finance Workflows**, **Ask Finance Peers**, and **Career & Compensation**.

2. Harshit Vora

Harshit is a strong candidate because he combines CFO-level responsibility with experience in finance, treasury and financial services. His recent public posts also show interest in the changing role of finance and AI.

He would be particularly relevant to **Finance Workflows** and **Tools & Systems**.

3. Sushanta Kumar Swain

Sushanta has extensive finance experience and is actively participating in conversations around AI, data and digital transformation in finance. His participation in the 2026 India CFO Summit is a useful recent signal that he is engaged with current finance topics.

He would bring useful experience to **Tools & Systems**, **Finance Workflows**, and **Ask Finance Peers**.

5. Priority Invitee

Selected: Dhiraj Kumar Vashista

I would choose **Dhiraj Kumar Vashista** as the first person to approach.

The main reason is the balance between his seniority and the breadth of his practical finance experience. His background covers FP&A, budgeting, governance, supply-chain optimisation and transformation, rather than being limited to one narrow finance area. HGS also officially lists him as Whole Time Director and CFO.

Another reason is that there is a recent public signal of his involvement in the finance leadership community. His 2026 recognition as one of the Best CFOs in India provides a reasonable indication that he is active professionally and has experience that could be useful to peers.

Why FoF could be relevant to him

I would not assume that he needs another professional community. Instead, I would position FoF around the opportunity to exchange practical experiences with other finance professionals.

The strongest areas would be:

- **Finance Workflows** — sharing practical approaches to finance operations and transformation.
- **Ask Finance Peers** — giving or receiving perspectives on real finance problems.
- **Career & Compensation** — sharing leadership and career lessons with other finance professionals.

These areas are consistent with the purpose described in the Friends of Finance guide.

6. What Is Verified vs What Is Assumed?

Verified

The following information is supported by public professional sources:

- Dhiraj Kumar Vashista is Whole Time Director and CFO at HGS (India) Limited.
- He has around 27 years of finance experience.
- His experience includes FP&A, governance, budgeting and transformation.
- He has received recent finance leadership recognition.
- His professional background is publicly available.

Assumed

The following should **not** be treated as facts:

- That he is currently looking for a finance community.
- That he would definitely be interested in Friends of Finance.
- That he has a specific problem that FoF can solve.
- That he would respond to an invitation.
- That he is interested in Volopay's products.

These would need to be discovered through a respectful interaction rather than assumed from his public profile.

7. When I Would Stop Pursuing the Invitation

I would use a limited outreach sequence rather than repeatedly contacting the person.

I would stop if:

1. He clearly says that he is not interested.
2. He asks not to be contacted.
3. He explains that the community is not relevant to him.
4. There is no response after the complete planned sequence.

I would only consider another approach later if there is a new and relevant professional signal, such as a public discussion about finance peer learning, finance transformation, or a topic that directly matches one of the Friends of Finance spaces.

8. Final Recommendation

Based on the available public information, my priority order is:

1. Dhiraj Kumar Vashista — Priority Invitee

Strong combination of finance leadership, FP&A, transformation and recent professional visibility.

2. Harshit Vora

Strong fit because of CFO, treasury and financial-services experience, with recent interest in AI and finance.

3. Sushanta Kumar Swain

Strong combination of long-term finance experience and current involvement in AI, data and digital finance discussions.

The selection is based on **publicly visible professional evidence and relevance to Friends of Finance**, not on an assumption that any of these individuals will join the community.

Sources Used

- HGS (India) Limited — official company information
- John Deere Financial India — official corporate disclosures
- Public LinkedIn professional profiles
- public finance leadership and conference information
- Friends of Finance Orientation Guide supplied with the assignment